Optima Academy Online
An Education Experience Company

PHILOSOPHY HONORS: ETHICS

On-Demand (Asynchronous)
Full Year · Grades 9–12

Start Here	Format	Scope
Course Syllabus	On-Demand (Asynchronous) · the only format this course offers	Full Year, 1.0 credit

Download: Course Syllabus (PDF)

This is the full syllabus for Philosophy Honors: Ethics. Download the PDF above, and read the same content in full below.

FACILITATOR & CONTACT

FACILITATOR
Optima Academy Online Faculty

FLORIDA COURSE
Florida 2105355 · Full-year elective · 1.0 credit

GRADE LEVEL
Grades 9–12

EMAIL & OFFICE
Your facilitator's email is posted in Canvas · 239.673.2801 (OAO Front Office)

OFFICE HOURS
Posted in Canvas · weekly study hall and VR workshops

FORMAT
On-Demand (asynchronous) · self-paced within each quarter

About this syllabus. This is the plan for the On-Demand (asynchronous) section of the course as designed. It is a full-year course; you pace through the four quarters of your enrolled year. Optima also offers this course as a Live section with the same content and expectations, described in its own syllabus. Exact pacing and a few activities may vary from term to term. Your facilitator will confirm the specifics for your section.

COURSE OVERVIEW

Philosophy Honors: Ethics is a yearlong survey of moral philosophy in the Western tradition, moving from the ancient search for moral knowledge through the major frameworks philosophers have used to answer it. Scholars begin with Plato's *Euthyphro* and the challenges of moral epistemology, move through utilitarian and Kantian accounts of consequence and duty, study Aristotle's virtue ethics and his account of human flourishing, and close with Aquinas's natural law tradition. Each quarter tests its framework against real objections and hard cases, and the course ends with a capstone essay comparing all four accounts of morality against one another.

WHAT SCHOLARS WILL LEARN TO DO

- Distinguish descriptive from normative claims and identify when a genuine ethical question arises.
- Evaluate the major challenges to moral knowledge: emotivism, moral relativism, and the fact/value gap.
- Compare consequentialist and Kantian accounts of right action, including utilitarianism and the categorical imperative.
- Explain Aristotle's account of *eudaimonia*, the virtues, and practical wisdom (*phronesis*).
- Apply the doctrine of the mean and the cardinal virtues to specific cases of character.
- Explain Aquinas's natural law theory, the doctrine of double effect, and the basic human goods.
- Evaluate applied ethical questions in medicine, war, and emerging technology using multiple frameworks.
- Construct and defend a reasoned position on which account of morality is most adequate.

BIG PROJECTS & MILESTONES

The course builds toward a capstone-depth essay at the close of each quarter. Target dates below follow a sample full-year pacing; you pace to your own enrolled term, keeping each milestone roughly in order.

Project / Milestone	Course Place	Sample Target	What You Turn In
Quarter 1 Reflection & Moral Autobiography	Moral Knowledge to How to Do Ethics · Weeks 1–9	by Oct 9, 2026	Two-part capstone: a reflection essay on Quarter 1's central questions, paired with a personal moral autobiography tracing the development of your own moral beliefs.
Quarter 2 Major Essay	Consequentialism and Deontology · Weeks 10–18	by Dec 18, 2026	A 700–900 word case-study comparison essay applying consequentialist and Kantian reasoning to the same moral dilemma. Fall semester ends.
Quarter 3 Synthesis Essay	Virtue Ethics and Aristotle · Weeks 19–27	by Mar 5, 2027	A 600–800 word essay defending or challenging Aristotle's central claim that eudaimonia consists in virtuous activity.
Course Capstone Essay	Natural Law and Synthesis · Weeks 28–36	by May 28, 2027	A 900–1200 word capstone essay comparing all four ethical frameworks studied this year and defending the most adequate account of morality. Course ends.

IMPORTANT DATES · 2026–2027

Aug 12, 2026	First day of school
Sep 7, 2026	Holiday (Labor Day)
Oct 9, 2026	Quarter 1 ends
Oct 12, 2026	Holiday (Columbus Day)
Nov 11, 2026	Holiday (Veterans' Day)
Nov 23–27, 2026	Thanksgiving break
Dec 18, 2026	Quarter 2 ends · fall semester ends
Dec 21, 2026–Jan 1, 2027	Winter break
Jan 5, 2027	Classes resume
Jan 18, 2027	Holiday (MLK Day)
Feb 15, 2027	Holiday (Presidents' Day)
Mar 5, 2027	Quarter 3 ends
Mar 26–Apr 5, 2027	Spring break
Apr 6, 2027	Classes resume
May 28, 2027	Quarter 4 ends · last day of school
May 31, 2027	Holiday (Memorial Day)

ASSESSMENT & GRADING

50%
Module Capstones (one per module, drawing on the whole module)

30%
Writing Assignments (weekly Assignments, Discussions, and Warm-Ups)

20%
Comprehension Checks

ON-DEMAND (ASYNCHRONOUS) LEARNING

In the On-Demand section you move through the course at your own pace within each quarter, guided by due dates that keep you on track. All assignments for a quarter open at its start and close at its end. Because the course is On-Demand, there is no grade penalty for

missing an individual due date; any assignment not completed by the end of the quarter receives a zero, and assignments submitted in the final 14 days of a quarter receive a 10% deduction, so steady pacing matters.

Attendance is measured by assignment completion. Per school policy, a scholar who completes no assignment for ten consecutive school days, without notifying the school of an absence in advance, may be dropped from the course. Completion means a sincere attempt: real effort on real work. Rushed work, wrong or corrupted files, irrelevant or nonsense submissions, AI-generated filler, and word-salad responses do not count.

> **You are never on your own.** A live facilitator grades your work, gives feedback, and hosts a weekly study hall and VR workshops.

This course is also taught as a Live (synchronous) section that meets on a schedule on Optima's VR campus. If that is the section you are enrolled in, use the Live syllabus instead of this one.

USING AI IN THIS COURSE

Optima's AI policy does not ask whether a scholar used AI. It asks whether AI was used honestly, skillfully, and in a way that genuinely built your own thinking. AI may support your work, but it may not do the reasoning an assignment asks of you.

WHICH AI TOOLS YOU MAY USE

- **Every scholar.** Any AI used for this course is school-controlled: tools built into Canvas assignments and into Optima's VR platform, set up to ask you questions and prompt your thinking rather than hand you answers. No assignment in this course requires a personal AI account.
- **Scholars under 14.** Your facilitator may not ask, suggest, or require that you use an AI tool outside those school-controlled platforms. Your AI work for this course happens in Canvas and in VR.
- **Scholars 14 and older.** Whether you use an outside AI tool for schoolwork is your family's decision, not the school's. It requires written parent or guardian permission on file with your facilitator, and your parent or guardian selects the tool, sets up the account, monitors it, and stays responsible for it. Optima does not provide, endorse, or manage personal AI accounts. Your facilitator's part is to judge whether the AI was used well.

WHAT IS EXPECTED WHEN YOU USE AI

- **Document it.** Record the tool, the prompt you gave it, and the date. Using AI is not plagiarism. Turning in AI-generated work as entirely your own thought, with no documentation, is.

- **Verify it.** AI states wrong things confidently, and you are responsible for every claim you submit, so check it against a credible source before it goes into your work. Verification is one of the skills this course grades.
- **Sound like yourself.** Your work should read the way you write and speak in the rest of the course, take a real position rather than hedging, and be something you can explain on the spot, on camera or in VR, when your facilitator asks a follow-up question you did not expect.
- **Keep the process, not just the product.** Prompt logs, drafts, revision notes, and VR recordings are gradeable evidence of your thinking. When an assignment asks for them, they count toward your grade.

Some assignments limit or exclude AI so that you build the underlying skill yourself, and the assignment page will say so. The reason is practical: you cannot judge whether an AI's answer is any good unless you can do the work without it.

LEARNING IN VIRTUAL REALITY

Optima is a virtual-reality school. Alongside your Canvas coursework, you will join immersive sessions on Optima's VR campus, where you meet teachers and fellow scholars, take part in live activities, and explore places and ideas you could not visit in an ordinary classroom. Keep your headset charged and ready for any scheduled VR sessions, and treat the VR campus with the same courtesy and seriousness you would a physical one. If you ever cannot get into VR for a session, tell your facilitator: there is an alternative way to take part so you do not fall behind.

BEING AN OPTIMA SCHOLAR

Optima's mission is an excellent, virtue-centered education, and virtue is at the center of this course as much as any other. Every scholar is expected to practice the seven virtues that shape life at Optima: courage, courtesy, honesty, perseverance, self-government, service, and responsibility. In practice that means: do your own honest work; treat everyone you meet in, through, or because of this course with respect, in writing, in discussion, and in VR; engage actively rather than passively; come to office hours to get help, meet other scholars, and get to know your facilitator; and take responsibility for your own pacing and progress. You belong to a house and a community of scholars, not only to a course.

WHAT YOU NEED & STAYING CONNECTED

☐ A computer with reliable internet and access to Canvas.

☐ A VR headset, charged and ready for scheduled immersive sessions.

☐ Microsoft 365 (Word, PowerPoint) with OneDrive, for documents you create and submit.

☐ A notebook or binder, and pens or pencils, for reading notes and primary source work.

Staying connected. Updates about this course are posted on the course's Canvas page; school-wide updates are posted in your Homeroom Canvas course. Check both regularly. Your facilitator holds office hours and is glad to help with the material, to meet you, or to talk through your plans: come by, or reach out any time by email.

Philosophy Honors: Ethics · On-Demand (asynchronous) section · Florida course 2105355 · Full-year course · Optima Academy Online, 2026–2027. Built from the course content and the board-approved 2026–2027 academic calendar. Project target dates reflect a sample full-year pacing; On-Demand scholars pace to their own enrolled term. School calendar dates may be adjusted by the school.

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